HCP 1142 (cpc_1906--_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-41): a love verse in numbers to Margitka Sziber

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Status: the cipher is deciphered in full (210 of 210 signs); independent review 1 verdict REVISE, findings addressed. One open word at the foot is unsure in spelling but secure in sense. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1142 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1142), part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When captured on 2026-11-02 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, category Substitution, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Margitka Sziber, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links a HistoCrypt article; it was not checked for this card, so we cannot say whether it discusses it.

The card is addressed in open writing to **Tek. Szépreményü Sziber Margitka kisasszonynak (Szomolya.) u. p. Bogács (Borsod m.)**: "To the Honourable, the promising Miss Margitka Sziber, Szomolya, post office Bogács, Borsod county", in north-east Hungary. It belongs to a series of cards from Mezőkövesd to Szomolya, in the same hand and cipher, many of them signed Árpád or Sz. A.; the dated cards of the series are from 1915 and 1916.

This card has no written date. The purple round stamp shows BORSOD and the year 1906; the lower arc may read ...GYE, so it may be a county seal and 1906 a seal year, not a posting date. The grey postmark cannot be read. No date is established. The picture side has only a printed tinted photograph and publisher's marks.



Message and address side (source/address-large.jpg)



Picture side, no writing (source/picture-large.jpg)

Method

The whole message is enciphered except two closing lines. The solver read every row from the high-resolution scan at 2 to 5 times enlargement and wrote the signs into a transcription; no OCR was used. Decoding starts from the key reconstructed on finished sister cards hcp-1174, 1178 and 1179. That key opened the card at once (`Kedves Margitkám, a lapodat megkaptam`). Six signs missing or tentative on those tables got their values from words on this card, and a seventh (`5.`) is discussed below. Word divisions are the solver's. The reproduction command, run from the repository root, is:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1142/work/decode.py
```

It checks the hashes of the scans, decodes the transcription, compares each line with the stated reading and prints the open lines, which are hard-coded.

Transcription (`|` divides words, `----` marks the ruled lines around the couplet):

```
7 1: 3 3. 1: 7, | 8 1. 3, 4, 1 8, 7 1' 8
1. | 5, 1. 9 0 3 1. 8, | 8 1: 4, 7 1. 9 8, 1. 8
1. 8 1: 5. 6, 1: 7 | 6, 1. 4. 0 6, | 8 1: 4,
0, 3, :1 5, 8, 1: 8 | 3. 1. 7, 1' 3, 6, 1. 9 | 5 1.
6 0 | :1 3 0, | 5, 1: 7. | 4 1: 5, 8 1: 4. 1: 7
----
1. 7. 8, | 8 0 6, 3 6 1. | 7. 1 3. 1: 8 6, 1: 7
8 1 6, 3 1: 6, 1 7 | 3. 1: 3, 2. 7, 1:
8, 1: | 3. 1. 4. | 1. | 3. 1 5, 1' 4, 6, 1. 7
5, 1: 4, 7. 1: 1, 1, | 8, 1: 3, 1: 8 8, 2. 7, 1:
----
1: | 7 1' 3, 8. 1' 6, | 9 1 2 1 6. | 5 1: 5. | 3. 1. 6,
6, 1: 8 | 7, 0 7 1. 8, | 1 3, 5 1. 8, 0 7
:1 3 3. 0, 9, 0, 5, 5, 1: 7 | 7, | 1. 7 1 | 3. 0 5,
8, 1. 8
8, 1: 6, 2. 7 1: 3 | 1. 9, | 8 1. 3, 1. 3 0 7
```

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution of Hungarian letters. Each letter is one sign: a digit, or a digit with a mark. A comma, dot or colon is part of the sign. The key does not separate o/ó, ö/ő or i/í.

sign	letter	sign	letter	sign	letter
0	o, ó	2	c	5.	ly (l on finished cards)
0,	ö, ő	2,	cs	6	j
1	i, í	2.	é	6,	n
1.	a	3	d	6.	ny
1:	e	3,	r	7	k
1' (high dot)	á	3.	v	7,	s
:1 (dots left)	ü	4	f	7.	sz
1,	b	4,	g	8	m
9	p	4.	gy	8,	t
9,	z	5	h	8.	ty
		5,	l		

The card has 210 cipher signs, 30 distinct, all in the table. New against the finished tables, and fixed by this card's words: 2 = c (piciny), 4 = f (felmegyek), 4. = gy (nagyon), 6 = j (jó), 6. = ny (nagyon, piciny), 8. = ty (kártyán). A wrong value gives no word in these places.

5. conflicts with the finished cards hcp-1178 and 1179, which give it as plain l. The card cannot separate l from ly: amelynek and hely here are the normal spellings of what this writer could spell amelnek and hel. The words are the same either way.

Plaintext

Enciphered part (line breaks of the verse, punctuation and capitals are editorial):

Kedves Margitkám!

A lapodat megkaptam, amelynek nagyon megörültem. Vasárnap ha jó üdő lesz, felmegyek.

Aszt mondja szívemnek mindenik verése:

Te vagy a világnak legszebb teremtése.

E kártyán piciny hely van, nem sokat írhatok.

Üdvözöllek, s aki voltam tenéked, az maradok.

Open text at the foot:

Számtalanszor csókollak mindanyájatokat (?), (Sz. A.)

Spellings as on the card: aszt (azt), üdő (idő, a dialect form, also on sister cards), mindenik (each one), tenéked (older form of neked). Accents on jó, üdő, szívemnek and írhatok are supplied, because the key has none. mindanyájatokat is printed as the card seems to show it; it is a form of mindnyájatokat.

The ruled lines above and below the couplet set the verse off. Both pairs rhyme in the cipher: verése / teremtése and írhatok / maradok.

English translation

Dear Margitka of mine! I received your card, which made me very glad. On Sunday, if the weather is good, I will come up.

Each of its beats says this to my heart:

You are the most beautiful creation in the world.

There is little room on this card, I cannot write much.

I greet you, and what I have been to you, that I will remain.

Countless times I kiss you all. (Sz. A.)

Slovak translation

Drahá moja Margitka! Tvoj lístok som dostal a veľmi ma potešil. V nedeľu, ak bude pekné počasie, prídem hore.

Každý jeho úder hovorí môjmu srdcu:

Ty si najkrajšie stvorenie sveta.

Na tomto lístku je málo miesta, veľa napísať nemôžem.

Pozdravujem ťa, a čím som ti bol, tým ostanem.

Nespočetnekrát vás všetkých bozkávam. (Sz. A.)

What remains uncertain

- **The foot word** `mindanyájatokat` **(?).** This is open writing, not cipher. `mind` and `-tokat` are clear, and the next letters are a clear a, n and a descender, so the card is not spelled `mindny...`. The middle has an a-like letter with a blotted side, an open c-like letter under an acute, a second descender with a tick near it, an o/a-like letter and a short stroke. We cannot match every stroke, and there are one or two more than this form needs. The sense "all of you" is secure: `-tokat` is the second-person plural accusative ending, `csókollak` needs a second-person object, and the phrase stands on sister cards hcp-1152, 1154, 1157 and 1172.
- **Last sign of** `maradok`**.** A 7 with a wedge below it. The wedge might be a comma, giving s, and it does not settle the matter graphically. The word stands on sense: `marados` is no word here.
- `8.` **in** `kártyán`**.** The dot has a thin pen drag under the next sign. At high enlargement it is a dot with a tail, not a comma, and plain 8 gives no word.
- `5.` is l or ly (see Key).
- `Sz. A.` The signature stands in a loop; the capital looks like A, and K was discussed on hcp-1178. The series signs the name Árpád in cipher.
- **The couplet** may be a quotation or popular verse; no source was looked for. `mindenik verése` is read as "each of its beats"; `szívemnek` could also be the possessor, "each beat of my heart says this".
- **Date:** not established. The stamp middle and the grey postmark could not be read.

Why the reading is trusted

One fixed key turns all 210 signs into continuous grammatical Hungarian with no gap. The rhyme verése / teremtése played no part in setting any value or reading, so it is independent support; írhatok / maradok is weaker, because `maradok` itself rests on sense. Recipient, address, closing formula, hand and the spellings `aszt` and üdő match the sister cards, and the Sunday visit fits hcp-1174.

Review and what changed

An independent reviewer (a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent) reran the command, wrote its own decoder with a separately typed table, and checked every row of the transcription against its own crops of the scan. It found no wrong sign and returned **REVISE** with five minor findings. None changed the transcription or the key values.

- **Foot word.** The first print, `mindnyájatokat`, was a normalised form. The text now gives the form seen, with its doubt.
- `5.` The conflict with finished cards was not stated; it is now, and `5.` no longer counts as part of a palatal pattern.
- **Independence.** The claim that both rhymes were independent was too strong, and the status of the sister cards was out of date. Both are corrected.
- `maradok`**.** The solution no longer leans towards a flourish; it says the wedge is open and the word stands on sense.
- **Seal.** The note that 1906 may be a seal year was added.